

Drift through shimmering lagoons and palm-fringed canals

At a Glance

State	Kerala
Key Hubs	Alleppey, Kumarakom, Kollam, Kasaragod
Best Time	September – March
Airport	Cochin International (~80 km from Alleppey)
Season	Avoid Jun–Aug peak monsoon for road travel
Famous For	Houseboats, rice-paddy islands, bird sanctuaries, ayurveda

Overview

Kerala's backwaters are a spectacular 900 km network of interconnected lakes, canals, rivers and lagoons that run parallel to the Arabian Sea coast. The labyrinthine waterway winds through coconut groves, vivid green paddy fields, fishing hamlets, and centuries-old churches, mosques and temples — offering an intimately peaceful window into rural Kerala life.

The houseboat experience aboard a Kettuvallam — a traditional rice barge converted into a floating boutique hotel — is the most iconic Kerala experience. These handcrafted vessels glide silently through Vembanad Lake and village canals, providing a slow-travel immersion unlike anywhere else in the world. The region hosts the famous Nehru Trophy Snake Boat Race every August.

Top Attractions

Alleppey (Alappuzha) — Venice of the East

The queen of the backwaters — a maze of canals, bridges and houseboats, hosting the world-famous Nehru Trophy Boat Race every second Saturday of August. The best place to board a houseboat and drift into the green heart of Kerala.



■ *Alleppey (Alappuzha) — Venice of the East*

Kumarakom Bird Sanctuary

A magical 14-acre sanctuary on the shores of Vembanad Lake. Between October and February, migratory birds from Siberia, Central Asia and the Himalayas — egrets, herons, darters, teals, and painted storks — flock here in spectacular numbers.



■ *Kumarakom Bird Sanctuary*

Kollam–Alleppey Backwater Cruise

An eight-hour state-ferry journey from Kollam to Alleppey that covers the entire length of the Kerala backwaters — the longest, cheapest and most scenic backwater journey available, passing through countless villages and narrow palm-lined canals.



■ *Kollam–Alleppey Backwater Cruise*

Kuttanad — The Rice Bowl of Kerala

The only place in Asia where paddy cultivation happens below sea level. The bright emerald rice fields surrounded by water create a surreal, almost unreal landscape that seems to defy geography itself.



■ *Kuttanad — The Rice Bowl of Kerala*

Local Cuisine & Flavours

- Kerala Fish Curry — sour Kudampuli-tamarind based fish curry served on banana leaf
- Karimeen Pollichathu — spiced pearl-spot fish wrapped and cooked in banana leaf
- Appam with Stew — lacy rice hoppers with coconut-milk vegetable or chicken stew
- Puttu & Kadala Curry — steamed rice cylinders with black chickpea curry
- Prawn Moilee — delicate, mild prawn coconut curry unique to the backwater coast

How to Get There

- By Air: Cochin International Airport (~80 km from Alleppey, ~40 km from Kumarakom).
- By Train: Alleppey station on the Ernakulam–Thiruvananthapuram main line.
- By Road: 80 km from Kochi via NH66 (~2 hrs); KSRTC buses and cabs available.
- By Boat: State Water Transport ferries connect Kottayam, Alleppey and Kollam.

Insider Travel Tips

- Book houseboats 2–3 months in advance for December–January peak season.
- One-night overnight cruise is far better than a day cruise — sunrise on the water is magical.
- Monsoon (June–August) has fewer tourists and the greenest scenery — a hidden gem timing.
- Negotiate hard for private houseboats rather than group packages for a personal experience.
- Carry mosquito repellent; the backwaters attract insects intensely after sunset.

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*We hope this guide inspires your journey to **Kerala Backwaters**. Travel responsibly, respect local traditions, and leave only footprints.*